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LASHKAR'S IDEOLOGY DAWA AND JIHAD

The purpose of this chapter is to examine Lashkar's ideology, as it developed during the group's formative years in the 1990s. This provides a baseline for assessing its activities during the 1990s and its evolution after 9/11, as well as a means of situating the group within the wider jihadi movement. The term 'jihadi' is recognizably problematic and rightly controversial. It is a neologism that misconstrues the traditional and theosophical meaning of the concept of jihad. The term is used here to connote those Sunni Muslims who, in contradistinction to most Muslims, regard jihad primarily as waging war and believe doing so is an individual obligation. Jihadi ideology—in terms of objectives and approach—has theological as well as political dimensions. Strategic calculation also plays a role in a jihadi group's decision-making. The jihadi movement includes pragmatists and ideologues, making it no different from most social movements, political parties or even governments. In some instances, seemingly immutable principles are bent to fit strategic necessity. Theology is often employed selectively to reconcile what are essentially pragmatic calculations. Because jihadis are also human beings, ideological rigor and strategic calculus sometimes give way to more pedestrian influences such as greed, loyalty or simply the desire to survive.

Jihadis generally share the same long-term political aims. Most can agree on establishing a pan-Islamic Caliphate or achieving Islam's complete dominance on Earth as end goals. Because these are utopian aims they offer limited utility for analysts who study jihadi groups, as well as for jihadis themselves. When considering where and how a jihadi group focuses its energy, it is better to focus on their short- and medium-term